

» EURO 2024 GROUP E PREVIEW

Fresh start: With a relatively young squad, Belgium looks to rebuild on the backbone of experienced players like Romelu Lukaku and Kevin De Bruyne. GETTY IMAGES

A REVAMPED SIDE COULD DO THE TRICK

A **new-look Belgium** seeks a strong run under Domenico Tedesco, with Ukraine posing the biggest challenge.

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Over the last decade, Belgium enjoyed the fruits of its 'Golden Generation' with some of the world's best players at the top of their game in the squad. Despite being one of the top-ranked teams by FIFA, the closest the 'Red Devils' ever came to a trophy was in the 2018 World Cup when they finished third.

As the older generation fades away, new coach Domenico Tedesco has named a relatively young squad for Euro 2024 as he looks to rebuild on the backbone of experienced players like Kevin De Bruyne, Jan Vertonghen, Axel Witsel, and Romelu Lukaku.

Belgium will face Slovakia, Romania, and Ukraine in Group E. Although they look fairly strong on paper, there are some underlying problems, especially at the back.

Belgium plays in a 4-3-3 formation, with its most capped player, 37-year-old Vertonghen, leading the backline. Alongside him will be either Wout Faes or Arthur Theate, who, having only joined the senior team in 2022, lack experience on the international stage.

Even star goalkeeper Thibaut Courtois has been left out of the squad due to injury concerns and a spat with Tedesco.

On the other hand, Belgium should be confident about its offence with the inclusion of exciting young players in its ranks.

Jeremy Doku (22), Johan Bakayoko (21), and Charles De Ketelaere (23) will bring pace and flair up front. With Eden Hazard retired, Leandro Trossard will be the first-choice left winger, coming off an excellent season with Arsenal.

De Bruyne will be the midfield general orchestrating the attacks, and at the front will be Lukaku, who was the top scorer (14) in the qualifying rounds.

Belgium's biggest threat in the group stage would be Ukraine, which could be the biggest dark horse of the tournament.

Ukraine playing for national pride

Ukraine was grouped with heavyweights England and Italy during qualifying, and although it gave a tough fight, it missed out on